MODULE 6

Is This Load Even Doable?

Ace Dispatch · Dispatcher Training Course

Module 6 of 18 · Finding & Judging the Load · about a 15-minute read

Marcus is sitting in Atlanta and you find a solid load to Dallas. The broker says, "Great — I need it there by tomorrow afternoon." You want the load, so you say, "No problem." You just made a promise you can't keep.

Atlanta to Dallas is about a thousand miles. That is not a one-day drive — it's *two.* To deliver by tomorrow afternoon, Marcus would have to drive sixteen, seventeen hours straight, which is both illegal and genuinely dangerous. So one of two bad things happens: either he refuses and you look like you don't know your job, or he tries it, runs out of legal hours two hundred miles short, and delivers late anyway — with an angry broker and a driver you put in a bad spot.

> *All of it was avoidable with about five minutes of math up front. Before you ever tell a broker "yes," you need to know whether the load is even possible.*

WHAT YOU'LL BE ABLE TO DO

Take a load's miles, its pickup and delivery times, and how many hours your driver has left, and tell — before you commit — whether he can legally and physically deliver on time. And when the answer is no, you'll know exactly what to do instead of promising the impossible.

1 The Clock Runs Everything

Here's the thing that surprises new dispatchers: the limit on a load usually isn't the truck or the miles — it's the *driver's hours.* A truck can run all day; a human legally cannot. The federal government caps how long a driver can be behind the wheel through **Hours of Service** — HOS. The reason is safety: tired drivers crash, so the law limits driving time, and it is not optional. Break it and you're looking at fines, a driver put out of service, and a hit to the carrier's safety record.

So you can't out-hustle the clock — you plan *around* it. Which means before you promise a delivery, you need two things: what the rules allow, and how to do the quick math.

2 The HOS Rules That Actually Matter

You don't need to be a compliance officer — just the handful of rules that decide whether a run fits. Think of the driver as having two budgets: a **daily** one and a **weekly** one.

THE DAILY BUDGET — after 10 hours off duty, the clock resets

11 hrs driving (max)

The full bar is the **14-hour on-duty window**, and it does **not** pause. Fueling, loading, waiting at a dock, lunch — the window keeps running. Come on duty at 6 a.m. and you can't drive after 8 p.m., even with driving hours to spare. *(Plus a 30-minute break after 8 cumulative hours of driving.)*

THE WEEKLY BUDGET — reset by a 34-hour restart

60 hrs / 7 days — or 70 hrs / 8 days

A rolling weekly cap (which one depends on the carrier). Near the ceiling, the driver is nearly out of road for the week until 34 straight hours off duty resets the count.

That's the whole framework: **11 driving hours inside a 14-hour window, reset by 10 off; 60 or 70 hours a week, reset by 34 off; a 30-minute break partway through.**

ALWAYS WORK FROM CURRENT FMCSA RULES

These are the standard federal property-carrier limits, and they're stable — but a few special exceptions exist (sleeper-berth splits, short-haul, adverse conditions), and rules can change. The budget above is what drives your everyday math; confirm specifics against the current FMCSA rules.

3 How You Know the Hours: the ELD

So how do you know how many hours a driver has left? You don't guess, and he doesn't either — because of the **ELD**, the Electronic Logging Device. It's connected to the truck's engine, automatically records driving time, and keeps the driver's hours-of-service log. Almost every truck is required to run one.

What that means for you is simple: a driver can tell you, at any moment, exactly how many hours he has left — so before you commit him to a run, you *ask*. "*How are your hours? How much do you have left today, and where are you on your week?*" His available hours are an input to every feasibility decision, right alongside the miles.

4 Transit-Time Math: the Number That Matters

Now the math, and it hinges on one realistic number. A new dispatcher does the wrong math: "11 hours of driving times 60 miles an hour equals 660 miles a day." That number is a fantasy — real driving loses time to traffic, construction, fueling, scales, the 30-minute break, finding parking, and waiting to load and unload.

The number you plan on for a solo driver is roughly **450 to 500 miles a day.** Some days are better, some worse, but that's the honest planning figure. So the core calculation is simple: **miles ÷ about 500 = the driving days you need** — rounded up, with a little buffer, because something always comes up.

Total miles	÷	Plan rate	=	Driving days	→	Delivery
~1,000 mi		**~500 / day**		**2 days**		**Thursday**
loaded (+150 deadhead)		honest solo figure (not 660)		round up + buffer		Tue AM + 2 days ✓

Run our furniture load through it: a thousand miles ÷ five hundred is two driving days. Pick up Tuesday morning, and two driving days puts delivery on **Thursday** — exactly the day the posting showed. That five-second division is the difference between a promise you can keep and one you can't.

5 The Feasibility Check, Start to Finish

Here's the whole check as a habit you run before you ever say yes:

1. **Total the miles.** The loaded miles, plus any deadhead to reach the pickup.
2. **Figure the driving days.** Miles ÷ about 500, rounded up.
3. **Check the start.** When can the driver actually begin — the pickup time, *and* how many hours he has on his clocks right now? A fresh driver and one with two hours left on his 14 are completely different answers.
4. **Project the delivery.** Add the driving days (and the required 10-hour rest each night) to the start, and see what day and time the load realistically arrives.
5. **Compare to the appointment, with buffer.** If your projected delivery — plus a cushion for weather, traffic, or a slow dock — lands on or before the required time, it's doable. If not, it is **not** doable, and you don't promise it.

When it's not doable, you have real options — pick one *before* committing, not after: negotiate a later delivery time, pass on the load, or, for a true rush, recognize it would need a team of two drivers running in shifts. What you never do is promise a run that forces the driver to break his hours. **A late load costs you a load; an illegal one can cost the driver his license and the carrier its authority.**

Walkthrough — Two Loads, One Question

Marcus, dry van, picking up near Atlanta; plan ~500 mi/day.

> **Scenario A — "Can we make it?"**
> Atlanta → Dallas · 1,000 mi · pickup Tue 8:00 AM · deliver **Thursday**
> Math: 1,000 ÷ 500 = 2 driving days. Tue AM + 2 days → Thursday. Marcus is fresh; half-day cushion before the appointment. → **DOABLE** — promise Thursday with confidence.

> **Scenario B — same load, tighter ask**
> Broker wants delivery **Wednesday morning** (~1 day after a Tue AM pickup)
> Math: 1,000 miles needs 2 driving days; one day covers ~500, not 1,000. Wednesday would mean ~16+ hrs driving in a day — illegal and impossible. **→ NOT DOABLE solo**. Options: ask for Thursday, pass, or it'd need a team. Don't say yes to Wednesday.

THE HOURS TRAP — WHY YOU ALWAYS ASK

Even a *short* load fails if the clock's already spent. If Marcus has 2 hours left in his 14-hour window and the drive is 4 hours, he can't finish it today — he needs a 10-hour reset first. Miles aren't the only input; the driver's hours are too.

Module 6 Glossary — your quick reference

The driver's clock, in one place.

Hours of Service

HOS (Hours of Service)	Federal limits on how long a driver may drive and be on duty — a safety law, not optional.
ELD	Electronic Logging Device — wired to the engine, it auto-records driving time and keeps the HOS log.
11-hour limit	The most a driver may drive after a 10-hour reset.
14-hour window	The on-duty window all driving must fit inside — it does *not* pause for fuel, loading, or waiting.
30-minute break	Required after 8 cumulative hours of driving.
10-hour reset	10 consecutive hours off duty — resets the daily 11 and 14.
60/70-hour limit	The rolling weekly on-duty cap: 60 hrs in 7 days, or 70 in 8 (carrier's choice).
34-hour restart	34 straight hours off duty — resets the weekly count.

Check yourself

Try these from memory first, then check your answers below.

1. **What are the two limits on a driver's day, and what resets them?**

2. **Why don't you plan a solo driver for 660 miles a day (11 hrs × 60 mph), and what number do you use instead?**

3. **Atlanta to Dallas is ~1,000 miles. Pickup Tuesday morning; the broker wants delivery Wednesday morning. Solo driver — doable? Why?**

4. **A driver has 2 hours left in his 14-hour window. The next drive is 4 hours. Can he do it today?**

5. **Your math says a load can't be delivered on time. What are your options, and what's the one thing you must never do?**

ANSWERS

1. At most 11 hours of driving, and all driving within a 14-hour on-duty window (which doesn't pause for breaks/fuel/loading). 10 consecutive hours off duty resets both. (Plus a 30-minute break after 8 hours of driving.)

2. Real driving loses time to traffic, fuel, scales, the break, parking, and loading/unloading. Plan on ~450–500 miles/day, rounded with a buffer.

3. No. 1,000 miles is ~2 driving days; one day covers only ~500. Wednesday-morning delivery would require ~16+ hours of driving in a day — illegal and impossible. Negotiate Thursday, pass, or it needs a team.

4. No — the 14-hour window closes before he finishes. He needs a 10-hour reset before he can complete that drive.

5. Negotiate a later delivery, pass on the load, or use a team for a true rush. Never promise a run that forces the driver to break HOS.

WHAT'S NEXT → MODULE 7: VETTING THE BROKER

Now you can find a load worth chasing and confirm your driver can legally get it there on time. There's one last thing to check before you commit your truck to anyone — the person on the other end of the deal. Is this broker actually legitimate? Will they pay you, or are they a problem — or even a scam? Next, we vet the broker, so you only put your truck behind freight that's real and money that's going to show up.

YOUR COMPANY'S PLAYBOOK

This lesson teaches feasibility with generic planning numbers. Your own operation adds its specifics — its planning miles-per-day assumption and standard buffer, the exact ELD/tracking system and how to read it, its policy on tight or impossible appointments (when to push back, who to escalate to), and any rules for team loads or rush freight. *Your trainer or supervisor will fill these in.*